

MODULE 2

Foundations of the Human Rights-Based Approach

Building the rights lens before project design, implementation, and MEAL.

Target audience: local and grassroots civil society organizations in Ethiopia.

Core message: move from delivering activities for “beneficiaries” to supporting rights-holders and duty-bearers to realize human rights in practice.



What is the Human Rights-Based Approach?

A practical way of working grounded in rights and obligations

HRBA places human rights and the people who hold those rights at the center of development action.

Intrinsic

It is morally and legally the right thing to do.

Instrumental

It addresses root causes and leads to more sustainable outcomes.

- 1 Which rights are at stake?
- 2 Who holds those rights?
- 3 Who has responsibility?
- 4 What barriers exist?
- 5 How can people participate and receive a response?

The Paradigm Shift: Charity, Needs, and Rights



Important: HRBA does not reject life-saving services or immediate support; it upgrades them by adding rights, agency, responsibility, and systemic accountability.

Identifying the Actors: Rights-Holders and Duty-Bearers

Rights-holders

Every individual and community member has voice, agency, and valid claims, regardless of gender, age, disability, or displacement status.

Not passive recipients of repeated support.



Duty-bearers

The State and its institutions remain the primary duty-bearers: national ministries, regional bureaus, woreda desks, and kebele administrations.

Traditional leaders and private actors also have responsibilities.

Respect Do not interfere or block rights.

Protect Stop third parties from violating rights.

Fulfil Plan, budget, and build services.

CSOs as Enablers and Connectors

Where does the CSO fit?

If the community holds the rights and the State bears the duty, CSOs become bridges — not substitutes for the State.

A strong HRBA practitioner helps rights-holders organize evidence and helps duty-bearers understand obligations, capacity gaps, and systemic solutions.



Avoid replacing public responsibility with repeated charity deliveries.

The Core Principles of HRBA: PANEL

PANEL reminds us that how we work is as important as what we deliver.



Participation

Active, free,
meaningful voice —
not just attendance.



Accountability

Clear responsibilities,
information, feedback,
and response.



Non-Discrimination & Equality

Identify and prioritize
people facing the
greatest barriers.



Empowerment & Capacity

Build rights-holder
skills and duty-bearer
capacity.



Legality

Ground claims in
recognized rights and
domestic law.

Use PANEL as a quick quality check for every decision, activity, and MEAL process.

Principle 1: Meaningful Participation vs Tokenism

Token attendance

Counts who came into the room but does not check whether people could understand, speak safely, or influence decisions.

- ! Steep stairs
- ! Dense notices in one language
- ! Few confident voices dominate

Meaningful influence

Designs participation so people can reach the room, understand information, speak with safety, and shape decisions.

- ✓ Accessible time and venue
- ✓ Visual aids and plain language
- ✓ Safe feedback circles

Unmasking Power Dynamics

Even in an accessible room, some voices dominate while others remain quiet. HRBA looks at three kinds of power.

Visible Power

Formal rules, laws, and authorities — such as an official budget decision.

Hidden Power

Control over who gets to the table and what gets discussed.

Invisible Power

Internalized beliefs and social norms that shape who feels safe to speak.

Navigating customary power respectfully

Customary elders and traditional structures are not the enemy; CSOs can bridge shared values and explain how inclusion benefits community development.

Principle 2: Overlapping Barriers and Intersectionality

One person, several barriers

A displaced young woman with a hearing impairment trying to access a livelihood registration process may face barriers that combine and reinforce one another.

HRBA asks: what must be intentionally removed so no one is left behind?

1

Displacement barrier

No local ID or proof of residence

2

Disability barrier

Instructions are only verbal

3

Gender & age barrier

Informal hierarchies bypass her

Design implication: plan for combined barriers, not one category at a time.

Principle 3: Constructive Accountability

Not just a complaint box

Accountability is a continuous loop of responsibility, information, feedback, response, correction, and learning.

Responsibility

Information

Feedback

Response

Correction & learning



Organized, safe evidence can turn frustration into productive dialogue and practical follow-up.

Principle 4: Plain Language Standards

From asking for aid...

“Please give us aid.”



...to recognized responsibilities

“We are here to help you fulfill your responsibilities.”

How to use standards safely

1

Use plain, everyday language

Avoid dense adversarial legal jargon.

2

Refer to recognized sources

National guidelines or the FDRE Constitution can be used carefully.

3

Invite collaboration

Respectfully connect community claims to practical action.

Embedding HRBA in Objectives, Processes, and Outcomes

HRBA is not a separate phase. It must be visible across the project cycle.

Objectives

Do aims target the realization of rights rather than only temporary outputs?

Processes

Are participation, non-discrimination, transparency, and accountability built into daily practice?

Outcomes

Do results strengthen rights-holder agency and duty-bearer capacity?

**Project
design
Implemen
tation
MEAL**

Summary: The Everyday Rights Lens Checklist



Rights & Actors

Which specific rights are at stake, who holds them, and who are the primary state duty-bearers?



Inclusion

Who is excluded, and what overlapping barriers do they face?



Participation

How will engagement be meaningful and influential, not token attendance?



Power

How are visible, hidden, and invisible power dynamics safely navigated?



Accountability

How will safe feedback, constructive dialogue, and recognized standards be used?

Conclusion and Next Steps: Moving to Project Design

HRBA is a practical structural shift

It is not only legal theory, not purely confrontational advocacy, and not just basic consultation.

This module built the everyday rights lens for project design, implementation, and MEAL.



Next, learners apply the lens

- Design interventions
- Rights-based objectives
- Logical frameworks
- MEAL outcomes

Foundations → Project Design → MEAL